

Japan Daily Brief

Monday, September 21, 2026

1,684 words · 7 min read

RE: Takaichi-Trump UNGA summit Tuesday · DPRK dual missile launch · BOJ rate check lifts yen · Typhoon Dujuan hits Tokyo area

NIKKEI 225
65,018.95
▲ +2.40%

USD/JPY
157.27
▲ +1.87%

BRENT
\$96.40
▼ -8.91%

BOJ RATE
1.25%

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Takaichi departs Japan for New York to address the UN General Assembly with a Trump bilateral confirmed for Tuesday, September 22, ahead of a US-China summit — Japan Times and Kyodo report she faces pressure on Taiwan, ICC sanctions, and tariffs.
- 2 North Korea fired two short-range ballistic missiles toward the East Sea on Sunday within a three-hour window, both falling outside Japan's EEZ; US, Japan, and South Korea held trilateral consultations in response per Yonhap.
- 3 Typhoon Dujuan made landfall across eastern Japan, issuing Level 4 danger warnings, canceling hundreds of flights, cutting transport services, and forcing the early close of the Tokyo Game Show on Japan's Respect for the Aged Day holiday.

• TOP STORIES

ALLIANCE

Takaichi heads to New York for Trump bilateral, faces Taiwan, ICC, and tariff pressures

Prime Minister **Sanae Takaichi** left Japan Monday for the UN General Assembly with a Tuesday bilateral with President **Donald Trump** confirmed — the meeting set the day before an anticipated US-China summit in Washington. The Japan Times reports she must thread concerns over Taiwan, possible US sanctions against the Japanese head of the ICC, and outstanding tariff issues simultaneously.

per The Japan Times: "Takaichi faces balancing act in meeting with Trump"

THE JAPAN TIMES

DPRK

North Korea fires two ballistic missiles within three hours; US-Japan-ROK consult

North Korea launched two suspected short-range ballistic missiles toward the East Sea on Sunday within a three-hour window, with South Korea's JCS reporting one flew approximately 440 km; both fell outside Japan's EEZ. The United States, Japan, and South Korea held trilateral consultations and issued a joint condemnation — the second North Korean launch in two weeks.

per Reuters: "North Korea fires two suspected ballistic missiles off east coast within three hours - Reuters"

REUTERS

ENERGY

Typhoon Dujuan drenches Tokyo area with Level 4 warnings; hundreds of flights canceled

Typhoon Dujuan brought heavy rain and strong winds to eastern Japan on Monday, with Level 4 danger warnings issued for some areas and hundreds of flights grounded, cutting short the Tokyo Game Show. The storm, tracking across the Izu Islands, is expected to restrengthen to typhoon intensity by Tuesday morning with sustained winds potentially reaching 80 mph.

per The Japan Times: "Powerful Typhoon Dujuan drenches Tokyo area"

THE JAPAN TIMES

• OVERNIGHT

TERRITORIAL DISPUTES

Nemuro, Japan's northernmost city, caught between Russian trade and island claims · NYT

The fishing town of Nemuro depends on Russia economically while simultaneously leading Japan's political push to reclaim islands seized by Moscow after World War II. The NYT report surfaces the local dimension of the territorial dispute amid Prime Minister Putin's recent visit to the contested islands.

ECONOMY-BOJ

SoftBank launches one of largest-ever junk bond deals to fund OpenAI investment · FT

SoftBank is seeking to raise *more than \$11 billion* in dollar and euro bonds to fund its expanding bet on the AI sector, anchored by its OpenAI stake. The deal ranks among the biggest high-yield issuances globally and reflects Japan's positioning as a capital hub for AI infrastructure.

KOREA-JAPAN

US, South Korea, Japan hold consultations after North Korea dual missile launch · Yonhap re Japan
South Korea, the United States, and Japan held trilateral consultations following North Korea's launch of two suspected short-range ballistic missiles toward the East Sea on Sunday. The launches fall outside Japan's EEZ but triggered Japan's enhanced surveillance posture and a joint condemnation.

INDO-PACIFIC

Japan and ASEAN trade ministers agree to strengthen economic partnership · Mainichi

Japan and ASEAN agreed at a September 20 industry and trade ministerial meeting in Manila to pursue a stronger economic partnership. The agreement comes as Japan deepens Southeast Asia ties amid shifting supply chains and US-China trade fragmentation.

• STAT OF THE DAY

29%

Japan's elderly population share — record high, highest globally (40M+ nations)

About 36.24 million people aged 65 or older now make up 29% of Japan's population, up 20,000 from a year earlier, per government data released September 21.

Japan's elderly population grows to its largest share yet — Japan Times

JAPANESE GOVERNMENT

KANTEI/PM · CABINET · MOFA · MOD · METI · MOF · BOJ · DIET · MONDAY, SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

PM Watch: PM appeared today · 0 day(s) since last confirmed appearance — Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi departed Japan for New York to attend the UN General Assembly, with a confirmed bilateral with President Trump on Tuesday, September 22.

防衛省 · MINISTRY OF DEFENSE (MOD) / JOINT STAFF

SDF recovers wreckage of crashed Global Hawk drone off western Japan coast

The Self-Defense Forces recovered part of a crashed Global Hawk unmanned aerial vehicle along the western Japan coast, Kyodo News reported. The incident drew attention inside Nikkei Asia's newsroom as a real-time editorial alert.

→ Kyodo News ↗

DIET SESSIONS / LDP

LDP

LDP tax policy chief Itsunori Onodera confirmed for continued term ahead of year-end consumption tax debate

The LDP's tax policy council chairmanship was confirmed for Itsunori Onodera, who will coordinate the party's positions on a potential food consumption tax cut heading into the year-end budget deliberations.

PUBLIC SENTIMENT & APPROVAL POLLING

POLLSTER	APPROVE	DISAPPROVE
Yomiuri · Sep 19, 2026	59%	30%
FNN · Sep 15, 2026	61.6%	32.2%
NHK · Sep 10, 2026	52.8%	30.8%
JNN · Sep 7, 2026	62.5%	34.9%
Nikkei · Sep 5, 2026	62%	32%
Asahi · Sep 5, 2026	53%	33%

ANN · Sep 5, 2026

55.4%

29.9%

Kyodo · Sep 10, 2026

50.2%

33.9%

Discourse: Post-reshuffle approval has stabilized across pollsters in the 53-62% range depending on house, reversing a pre-reshuffle slide to a record low of 50.2% (Kyodo) and 44.1% (Jiji); fiscal concerns over the food tax cut remain a drag identified in Kyodo and Mainichi surveys.

Poll tracker: [Observing Japan approval-rating aggregator](#) →

• BUSINESS & ECONOMY

FINANCE · CNBC

Japan markets defied convention after BOJ hike: stocks up, yen down, yields slip

After the BOJ's rate hike to 1.25%, the yen weakened past 157 against the dollar, the 10-year JGB yield slipped, and the Nikkei 225 gained 1.5% — the opposite of a typical tightening-cycle response. CNBC attributes the pattern to market pricing that the hike cycle will be gradual and that BOJ tightening has become entangled in US dollar dynamics.

REGIONAL PRESSURE WATCH

High — 91 items (8 Japanese government, 83 adversary signal; DPRK dominated with 79 items)

CHINA

China's Foreign Ministry labeled Japan's deployment of the US Typhon intermediate-range ground-launched cruise missile system 'another indication of its accelerating remilitarization,' per Global Times. Beijing's FM spokesperson separately declined to confirm whether the US-China Washington summit will address China's rare-earth export controls affecting Japan — leaving the critical-minerals leverage question unresolved heading into the summit.

NORTH KOREA

North Korea fired two suspected short-range ballistic missiles toward the East Sea on Sunday within a three-hour window; South Korea's JCS reported one flew approximately 440 km from the Wonsan area. Both splashed down outside Japan's EEZ; Japan tightened surveillance and joined US and South Korea in trilateral consultations and a joint condemnation — the second North Korean launch in two weeks.

RUSSIA

No new Russian military or territorial-dispute activity toward Japan is reported in today's articles beyond the sustained rhetorical escalation of recent weeks; the NYT profiles Nemuro's dual dependence on Russia economically and politically, illustrating the local dimension of the dispute.

Senkaku / ECS: No new China Coast Guard patrol data, intrusion, or scramble is reported in today's articles; China's Typhon missile-system condemnation continues its pattern of rhetorical pressure without new physical action in the East China Sea.

"Japan's introduction of Typhon intermediate-range missile system another indication of its accelerating 'remilitarization'"

Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson · Japan's introduction of Typhon intermediate-range missile system another indication of its accelerating 'remilitarization': Chinese FM — Global Times

Bottom line: North Korea's second dual-missile launch in two weeks lands on the eve of the Takaichi-Trump bilateral, handing Tokyo a concrete security data point to table; China's deliberate silence on whether rare-earth controls will feature in the US-China summit is the higher-consequence variable to track Tuesday.

• INDO-PACIFIC PARTNERS

TRILATERAL · YONHAP

US-Japan-ROK foreign ministers set for New York talks on economic and security ties

The foreign ministers of South Korea, the United States, and Japan are scheduled to meet in New York on the margins of UNGA to discuss economic and security ties, per Yonhap.

SOUTHEAST ASIA · INQUIRER.NET

New Japan envoy to Philippines pledges to deepen ties under highest-level pact

Japan's new ambassador to the Philippines vowed to deepen bilateral ties under the countries' highest-level partnership agreement, reinforcing Japan's South and Southeast Asia partner network.

TRILATERAL · GLOBAL TIMES RE JAPAN

Global Times: US-Japan-ROK Arctic cooperation plan raises 'security competition concerns'

Chinese state media framed a proposed US-Japan-ROK Arctic cooperation plan as raising geopolitical and security competition concerns — a reaction-source signal to note for Beijing's posture toward trilateral partner initiatives.

• THE WIRE

CHINA-JAPAN

GLOBAL TIMES

China's FM labels Typhon missile deployment further evidence of Japan 'remilitarization'

China's Foreign Ministry characterized Japan's deployment of the US Typhon intermediate-range ground-launched cruise missile system as another indication of Japan's accelerating remilitarization, per Global Times — continuing Beijing's rhetorical escalation on the missile deployment that Russia also protested last week.

GLOBAL TIMES

China's FM declines to confirm whether US-China summit will address rare-earth controls on Japan

China's Foreign Ministry spokesperson declined to say whether the upcoming US-China Washington summit would address Beijing's rare-earth export controls affecting Japan, per Global Times — leaving Tokyo uncertain about whether the bilateral will ease or entrench the controls.

TECHNOLOGY

NIKKEI ASIA

Japan plans to use industrial machinery as physical AI data-collection infrastructure

Japan is developing a framework to tap its industrial machinery base for collecting physical-world AI training data, positioning the country's manufacturing sector as a node in the global AI data supply chain.

ALLIANCE

JAPAN TODAY

Ukraine requests Zelenskyy-Takaichi bilateral on UNGA sidelines

Ukraine has requested a meeting between President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and Prime Minister Takaichi on the margins of the UN General Assembly, adding a Ukraine dimension to Takaichi's New York diplomatic schedule alongside the Trump bilateral.

• UPCOMING

Sep
21

Typhoon Dujuan impact assessment — transport, agriculture, infrastructure

Dujuan is expected to strengthen to typhoon status by Tuesday morning with sustained winds potentially reaching 80 mph; the Izu Islands remain under evacuation warnings and damage assessment is ongoing.

Sep
22

Takaichi-Trump bilateral at UNGA, New York

Prime Minister Takaichi meets President Trump on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly on Tuesday; tariffs, Taiwan, and the US-China summit are expected agenda items.

Sep
22

US-China summit anticipated in Washington

A Trump-Xi meeting is expected in Washington following the UNGA week; Japan is monitoring its outcome closely given its direct stakes in any US-China economic or security deal.

Sep
22

US-Japan-ROK Foreign Ministers trilateral, New York

Foreign ministers of South Korea, the United States, and Japan are scheduled to meet in New York on the margins of UNGA to discuss economic and security ties, per Yonhap.

Dec
1

Cabinet draft budget deadline (estimated)

Japan's annual cabinet budget draft is typically finalized in December, with FY2027 requests already at a record level; tax break requests and defense allocations will be the central battleground.

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